

A look from D'Artagnan, a look as keen and piercing as a sword-blade, found nothing in the heart of the old man but a simple confidence—on his features, nothing but satisfaction and indifference. He said, 'M. Fouquet will have it so,' as he would have said, 'God has willed it.'

D'Artagnan had already advanced too far in this direction; besides, the chandals being gone, there remained nothing at Piriac but a single bark—that of the old man, and it did not look fit for sea without great preparation. D'Artagnan therefore parted Furet, who, as a new proof of his charming character, resumed his march with his feet in the salt-mines, and his nose to the dry wind, which bends the furze and the broom of this country. They reached Le Croisic about five o'clock.

If D'Artagnan had been a poet, it was a beautiful spectacle: the immense strand of a league or more, the sea covers at high tide, and which, at the reflux, appears gray and desolate, strewn with polypi and seaweed, with pebbles sparse and white, like bones in some vast old cemetery. But the soldier, the politician, and the ambitious man, had no longer the sweet consolation of looking towards heaven to read there a hope or a warning. A red sky signifies nothing to such people but wind and disturbance. White and fleecy clouds upon the azure only say that the sea will be smooth and peaceful. D'Artagnan found the sky blue, the breeze embalmed with saline perfumes, and he said: 'I will embark with the first tide, if it be but in a nutshell.'

At Le Croisic as at Piriac, he had remarked enormous heaps of stone lying along the shore. These gigantic walls, diminished every tide by the barges for Belle-Isle, were, in the eyes of the musketeer, the consequence and the proof of what he had well divined at Piriac. Was it a wall that M. Fouquet was constructing? Was it a fortification that he was erecting? To ascertain that, he must make fuller observations. D'Artagnan put Furet into a stable; supped, went to bed, and on the morrow took a walk upon the port or rather upon the shingle. Le Croisic has a port of fifty feet; it has a look-out which resembles an enormous brioche (a kind of cake) elevated on a dish. The flat strand is the dish. Hundreds of barrowsful of earth amalgamated with pebbles, and rounded into cones, with sinuous passages between, are look-outs and brioches at the same time. It is so now, and it was so two hundred years ago, only the brioche was not so large, and probably there were to be seen to trellises of lath around the brioche,

which constitute an ornament, planted like gardes-fous along the passages that wind towards the little terrace. Upon the shingle lounged three or four fishermen talking about sardines and shrimps. D'Artagnan, with his eyes animated by a rough gayety, and a smile upon his lips, approached these fishermen.

'Any fishing going on to-day?' said he.

'Yes, monsieur,' replied one of them, 'we are only waiting for the tide.'

'Where do you fish, my friends?'

'Upon the coasts, monsieur.'

'Which are the best coasts?'

'Ah, that is all according. The tour of the isles, for example?'

'Yes, but they are a long way off, those isles, are they not?'

'Not very; four leagues.'

'Four leagues! That is a voyage.'

The fishermen laughed in M. Agnan's face.

'Hear me, then,' said the latter with an air of simple stupidity; 'four leagues off you lose sight of land, do you not?'

'Why, not always.'

'Ah, it is a long way—too long, or else I would have asked you to take me aboard, and to show me what I have never seen.'

'What is that?'

'A live sea-fish.'

'Monsieur comes from the province?' said a fisherman.

'Yes, I come from Paris.'

The Breton shrugged his shoulders; then:

'Have you ever seen M. Fouquet in Paris?' asked he.

'Often,' replied D'Artagnan.

'Often!' repeated the fishermen, closing their circle round the Parisian.

'Do you know him?'

'A little; he is the intimate friend of my master.'

'Ah!' said the fishermen, in astonishment.

'And,' said D'Artagnan, 'I have seen all his châteaux of Saint Mandé, of Vaux, and his hotel in Paris.'

'Is that a fine place?'

'Superb.'

'It is not so fine a place as Belle-Isle,' said the fisherman.

'Bah!' cried M. d'Artagnan, breaking into a laugh so loud that he angered all his auditors.

'It is very plain that you have never seen Belle-Isle,' said the most curious of the fishermen. 'Do you know that there are six leagues of it, and that there are such trees on it as cannot be equaled even at Nâtes-sur-le-Fosse?'

'Trees in the sea!' cried D'Artagnan; 'well, I should like to see them.'

'That can be easily done; we are fishing at the Isle de Hoedic—come with us. From that place you will see, as a Paradise, the black trees of Belle-Isle against the sky; you will see the white line of the castle, which cuts the horizon of the sea like a blade.'

'Oh,' said D'Artagnan, 'that must be very beautiful. But do you know there are a hundred belfries at M. Fouquet's château of Vaux?'

The Breton raised his head in profound admiration, but he was not convinced. 'A hundred belfries! Ah, that may be; but Belle-Isle is finer than that. Should you like to see Belle-Isle?'

'Is that possible?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Yes, with permission of the governor.'

'But I do not know the governor.'

'As you know M. Fouquet, you can tell your name.'

'Oh, my friends, I am not a gentleman.'

'Everybody enters Belle-Isle,' continued the fisherman in his strong, pure language, 'provided he means no harm to Belle-Isle or its master.'

A slight shudder crept over the body of the musketeer. 'That is true,' thought he. 'Then recovering himself, 'If I were sure,' said he, 'not to be sea-sick.'

'What, upon her?' said the fisherman, pointing with pride to his pretty round-bottomed bark.

'Well, you almost persuade me,' cried M. Agnan; 'I will go and see Belle-Isle, but they will not admit me.'

'We shall enter, safe enough.'

'You! What for?'

'Why, damel! to sell fish to the corsairs.'

'Ha! Corsairs—what do you mean?'

'Well, I mean that M. Fouquet is having two corsairs built to chase the Dutch and the English, and we sell our fish to the crews of those little vessels.'

'Eh! because the chalands (barges) are fresh-water boats, and take the sea badly,' replied the fisherman.

'That is not sufficient reason.'

'Pardon me, monsieur, one may see that you have never been a sailor,' added the fisherman, not without a sort of disdain.

'Explain to me, if you please, my good man. It appears to me that to come from Paimboeuf to Piriac, and go from Piriac to Belle-Isle, is as if we went from Roche-Bernard to Nantes, and from Nantes to Piriac.'

'By water that would be the nearest way,' replied the fisherman impatiently.

'But there is an elbow?'

The fisherman shook his head.

'The shortest road from one place to another is a straight line,' continued D'Artagnan.

'You forget the tide, monsieur.'

'Well! take the tide.'

'And the wind.'

'Well, and the wind.'

'Without doubt; the current of the Loire carries barks almost as far as Croisic. If they want to lie by a little, or to refresh the crew, they come to Piriac along the coast; from Piriac they find another inverse current, which carries them to the Isle-Dumal, two leagues and a half.'

'Granted.'

'There the current of the Vilaine throws them upon another isle, the Isle of Hoedic.'

'I agree with that.'

'Well, monsieur, from that isle to Belle-Isle the way is quite straight. The sea, broken both above and below, passes like a canal—like a mirror between the two isles; the chalands glide along upon it like ducks upon the Loire; that's how it is.'

'It does not signify,' said the obstinate M. Agnan; 'it is a long way round.'

'Ah! yes; but M. Fouquet will have it so,' replied, as conclusive, the fisherman, taking off his woolen cap at the enunciation of that respected name.

three other steeples, Guérande, Le Poulguen, and Saint-Joachim, which, in their circumference, represented a set of skittles, of which he and Furet were but the wandering ball. Piriac was the first little port on his right. He went thither, with the names of the principal salters on his lips. At the moment he reached the little port of Piriac, five large barges, laden with stone, were leaving it. It appeared strange to D'Artagnan, that stones should be leaving a country where none are found. He had recourse to all the amenity of M. Agnan to learn from the people of the port the cause of this singular arrangement. An old fisherman replied to M. Agnan, that the stones very certainly did not come from Piriac or the marshes.

'Where do they come from, then?' asked the musketeer.

'Monsieur, they come from Nantes and Paimboeuf.'

'Where are they going, then?'

'Monsieur, to Belle-Isle.'

'Ah! ah!' said D'Artagnan, in the same tone he had assumed to tell the printer that his character interested him; 'are they building at Belle-Isle, then?'

'Why, yes, monsieur, M. Fouquet has the walls of the castle repaired every year.'

'It is in ruins, then?'

'It is old.'

'Thank you.'

'The fact is,' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'nothing is more natural; every proprietor has a right to repair his own property. It would be like telling me I was fortifying the Image-de-Notre-Dame, when I was simply obliged to make repairs. In good truth, I believe false reports have been made to his majesty, and he is very likely to be in the wrong.'

'You must confess,' continued he then, aloud, and addressing the fisherman—for his part of a suspicious man was imposed upon him by the object even of his mission—'you must confess, my dear monsieur, that these stones travel in a very curious fashion.'

'How so?' said the fisherman.

'They come from Nantes or Paimboeuf by the Loire, do they not?'

'With the tide.'

'That is convenient,—I don't say it is not; but why do they not go straight from Saint-Nazaire to Belle-Isle?'

'Come, come!' said D'Artagnan to himself—'better and better. A printing-press, bastions, and corsairs! Well, M. Fouquet is not an enemy to be despised, as I presumed to fancy. He is worth the trouble of travelling to see him nearer.'

'We set out at half-past five,' said the fisherman gravely.

'I am quite ready, and I will not leave you now.' So D'Artagnan saw the fishermen haul their barks to meet the tide with a windlass. The sea rose; M. Agnan allowed himself to be hoisted on board, not without sporting a little fear and awkwardness, to the amusement of the young beach-urchins who watched him with their large intelligent eyes. He laid himself down upon a folded sail, not interfering with anything whilst the bark prepared for sea; and, with its large square sail, it was fairly out within two hours. The fishermen, who prosecuted their occupation as they proceeded, did not perceive that their passenger had not become pale, neither groaned nor suffered; that in spite of that horrible tossing and rolling of the bark, to which no hand impaired direction, the novice passenger had preserved his presence of mind and his appetite. They fished, and their fishing was sufficiently fortunate. To lines bated with prawn, soles came, with numerous gambols, to bite. Two nets had already been broken by the immense weight of congers and haddocks; three sea-eels plowed the hold with their slimy folds and their dying contortions. D'Artagnan brought them good luck; they told him so. The soldier found the occupation so pleasant, that he put his hand to the work—that is to say, to the lines—and uttered roars of joy, and mordious enough to have astonished his musketeers themselves, every time that a shock given to his line by the captured fish required the play of the muscles of his arm, and the employment of his best dexterity. The party of pleasure had made him forget his diplomatic mission. He was struggling with a very large conger, and holding fast with one hand to the side of the vessel, in order to seize with the other the gaping jowl of his antagonist, when the master said to him, 'Take care they don't see you from Belle-Isle!'

These words produced the same effect upon D'Artagnan as the hissing of the first bullet on a day of battle; he let go of both line and conger, which, dragging each other, returned again to the water. D'Artagnan perceived, within half a league at most, the blue and marked profile of the rocks of Belle-Isle, dominated by the majestic whiteness of the castle.

In the distance, the land with its forests and verdant plains; cattle on the grass. This was what first attracted the attention of the musketeer. The sun darted its rays of gold upon the sea, raising a shining mist round this enchanted isle. Little could be seen of it, owing to this dazzling light, but the salient points, every shadow was strongly marked, and cut with bands of darkness the luminous fields and walls. 'Eh! eh!' said D'Artagnan, at the aspect of those masses of black rocks, 'these are fortifications which do not stand in need of any engineer to render a landing difficult. How the devil can a landing be effected on that isle which God has defended so completely?'

'This way,' replied the patron of the bark, changing the sail, and impressing upon the rudder a twist which turned the boat in the direction of a pretty little port, quite coquettish, round, and newly battlemented.

'What the devil do I see yonder?' said D'Artagnan.

'You see Locmaria,' replied the fisherman.

'Well, but there?'

'That is Bangor.'

'And further on?'

'Sauzon, and then Le Palais.'

'Mordionx! It is a world. Ah! there are some soldiers.'

'There are seventeen hundred men in Belle-Isle, monsieur,' replied the fisherman, proudly. 'Do you know that the least garrison is of twenty companies of infantry?'

'Mordionx!' cried D'Artagnan, stamping with his foot. 'His majesty was right enough.'

They landed.

Chapter LXVIII

D'Artagnan Continues his Investigations



That daybreak D'Artagnan saddled Furet, who had fared sumptuously all night, devouring the remainder of the oats and hay left by his companions. The musketeer sifted all he possibly could out of the host, who he found cunning, mistrustful, and devoted, body and soul, to M. Fouquet. In order not to awaken the suspicions of this man, he carried on his fable of being a probable purchaser of some salt-mines. To have embarked for Belle-Isle at Roche-Bernard, would have been to expose himself still further to comments which had, perhaps, been already made, and would be carried to the castle. Moreover, it was singular that this traveller and his lackey should have remained a mystery to D'Artagnan, in spite of all the questions addressed by him to the host, who appeared to know him perfectly well. The musketeer then made some inquiries concerning the salt-mines, and took the road to the marshes, leaving the sea on his right, and penetrating into that vast and desolate plain which resembles a sea of mud, of which, here and there, a few crests of salt silver the undulations. Furet walked admirably, with his little nervous legs, along the foot-wide causeways which separate the salt-mines. D'Artagnan, aware of the consequences of a fall, which would result in a cold bath, allowed him to go as he liked, contenting himself with looking at, on the horizon, three rocks, that rose up like lance-blades from the bosom of the plain, destitute of verdure. Piriac, the bourgeois of Batz and Le Croisic, exactly resembling each other, attracted and suspended his attention. If the traveller turned round, the better to make his observations, he saw on the other side an horizon of

Chapter LXIX

D'Artagnan Was To Meet an Old Acquaintance



HERE is always something in a landing, if it be only from the smallest sea-boat—a trouble and a confusion which do not leave the mind the liberty of which it stands in need in order to study at the first glance the new locality presented to it. The moveable bridges, the agitated sailors, the noise of the water on the pebbles, the cries and importunities of those who wait upon the shores, are multiplied details of that sensation which is summed up in one single result—hesitation. It was not, then, till after standing several minutes on the shore that D'Artagnan saw upon the port, but more particularly in the interior of the isle, an immense number of workmen in motion. At his feet D'Artagnan recognized the five chalands laden with rough stone he had seen leave the port of Piriac. The smaller stones were transported to the shore by means of a chain formed by twenty-five or thirty peasants. The large stones were loaded on trollies which conveyed them in the same direction as the others, that is to say, towards the works, of which D'Artagnan could as yet appreciate neither the strength nor the extent. Everywhere was to be seen an activity equal to that which Telemachus observed on his landing at Salentum. D'Artagnan felt a strong inclination to penetrate into the interior; but he could not, under the penalty of exciting mistrust, exhibit too much curiosity. He advanced then little by little, scarcely going beyond the line formed by the fishermen on the beach, observing everything, saying nothing, and meeting all suspicion that might have been excited with a half-silly question or a polite bow. And yet, whilst his companions carried

on their trade, giving or selling their fish to the workmen or the inhabitants of the city, D'Artagnan had gained by degrees, and, reassured by the little attention paid to him, he began to cast an intelligent and confident look upon the men and things that appeared before his eyes. And his very first glance fell on certain movements of earth about which the eye of a soldier could not be mistaken. At the two extremities of the port, in order that their fires should converge upon the great axis of the ellipse formed by the basin, in the first place, two batteries had been raised, evidently destined to receive flank pieces, for D'Artagnan saw the workmen finishing the platform and making ready the demi-circumference in wood upon which the wheels of the pieces might turn to embrace every direction over the epaulement. By the side of each of these batteries other workmen were strengthening gabions filled with earth, the lining of another battery. The latter had embrasures, and the overseer of the works called successively men who, with cords, tied the saucissons and cut the lozenges and right angles of turfs destined to retain the matting of the embrasures. By the activity displayed in these works, already so far advanced, they might be considered as finished: they were not yet furnished with their cannons, but the platforms had their gites and their mardiers all prepared; the earth, beaten carefully, was consolidated; and supposing the artillery to be on the island, in less than two or three days the port might be completely armed. That which astonished D'Artagnan, when he turned his eyes from the coast batteries to the fortifications of the city, was to see that Belle-Isle was defended by an entirely new system, of which he had often heard the Comte de la Fère speak as a wonderful advance, but of which he had as yet never seen the application. These fortifications belonged neither to the Dutch method of Marollais, nor to the French method of the Chevalier Antoine de Ville, but to the system of Manesson Mallet, a skillful engineer, who about six or eight years previously had quitted the service of Portugal to enter that of France. The works had this peculiarity, that instead of rising above the earth, as did the ancient ramparts destined to defend a city from escalades, they, on the contrary, sank into it; and what created the height of the walls was the depth of the ditches. It did not take long to make D'Artagnan perceive the superiority of such a system, which gives no advantage to cannon. Besides, as the fosses were lower than, or on a level with, the sea, these fosses could be instantly inundated by means

the boat. As to the opulent traveller, he did the same with his two horses and servant. But all the wit D'Artagnan employed in endeavouring to find out his name was lost—he could learn nothing. Only he took such notice of his countenance, that it was impressed upon his mind forever. D'Artagnan had a great inclination to embark with the two travelers, but an interest more powerful than curiosity—that of success—repelled him from the shore, and brought him back again to the hostelry. He entered with a sigh, and went to bed directly in order to be ready early in the morning with fresh ideas and the sage counsel of sufficing sleep.

'Well, then, take the letters thus, which compose the word, you see: A B; ma foi! here is an R, two E, then a G.' And he assembled the letters with a swiftness and skill which did not escape the eye of D'Artagnan.

'Abrege,' said he, as he ended.

'Good!' said D'Artagnan; 'there are plenty of letters got together; but how are they kept so?' And he poured out a second glass for the poet. M. Jupenet smiled like a man who has an answer for everything; then he pulled out—still from his pocket—a little metal ruler, composed of two parts, like a carpenter's rule, against which he put together, and in a line, the characters, holding them under his left thumb.

'And what do you call that little metal ruler?' said D'Artagnan, 'for, I suppose, all these things have names.'

'This is called a composing-stick,' said Jupenet; 'it is by the aid of this stick that the lines are formed.'

'Come, then, I was not mistaken in what I said; you have a press in your pocket,' said D'Artagnan, laughing with an air of simplicity so stupid, that the poet was completely his dupe.

'No,' replied he; 'but I am too lazy to write, and when I have a verse in my head, I print it immediately. That is a labour spared.'

'Mordieux!' thought D'Artagnan to himself, 'this must be cleared up.' And under a pretext, which did not embarrass the musketeer, who was fertile in expedients, he left the table, went downstairs, ran to the shed under which stood the poet's little cart, and poked the point of his poniard into the stuff which enveloped one of the packages, which he found full of types, like those which the poet had in his pocket.

'Humph!' said D'Artagnan, 'I do not yet know whether M. Fouquet wishes to fortify Belle-Isle; but, at all events, here are some spiritual munitions for the castle.' Then, enchanted with his rich discovery, he ran upstairs again, and resumed his place at the table.

D'Artagnan had learnt what he wished to know. He, however, remained, none the less, face to face with his partner, to the moment when they heard from the next room symptoms of a person's being about to go out. The printer was immediately on foot; he had given orders for his horse to be got ready. His carriage was waiting at the door. The second traveller got into his saddle, in the courtyard, with his lackey. D'Artagnan followed Jupenet to the door; he embarked his cart and horse on board

of subterranean sluices. Otherwise, the works were almost complete, and a group of workmen, receiving orders from a man who appeared to be conductor of the works, were occupied in placing the last stones. A bridge of planks thrown over the fosses for the greater convenience of the manœuvres connected with the barrows, joined the interior to the exterior. With an air of simple curiosity D'Artagnan asked if he might be permitted to cross the bridge, and he was told that no order prevented it. Consequently he crossed the bridge, and advanced towards the group.

This group was superintended by the man whom D'Artagnan had already remarked, and who appeared to be the engineer-in-chief. A plan was lying open before him upon a large stone forming a table, and at some paces from him a crane was in action. This engineer, who by his evident importance first attracted the attention of D'Artagnan, wore a justaucorps, which, from its sumptuousness, was scarcely in harmony with the work he was employed in, that rather necessitated the costume of a master-mason than of a noble. He was a man of immense stature and great square shoulders, and wore a hat covered with feathers. He gesticulated in the most majestic manner, and appeared, for D'Artagnan only saw his back, to be scolding the workmen for their idleness and want of strength.

D'Artagnan continued to draw nearer. At that moment the man with the feathers ceased to gesticulate, and, with his hands placed upon his knees, was following, half-bent, the effort of six workmen to raise a block of hewn stone to the top of a piece of timber destined to support that stone, so that the cord of the crane might be passed under it. The six men, all on one side of the stone, united their efforts to raise it to eight or ten inches from the ground, sweating and blowing, whilst a seventh got ready for when there should be daylight enough beneath it to slide in the roller that was to support it. But the stone had already twice escaped from their hands before gaining a sufficient height for the roller to be introduced. There can be no doubt that every time the stone escaped them, they bounded quickly backwards, to keep their feet from being crushed by the refalling stone. Every time, the stone, abandoned by them, sunk deeper into the damp earth, which rendered the operation more and more difficult. A third effort was followed by no better success, but with progressive discouragement. And yet, when the six men were bent

towards the stone, the man with the feathers had himself, with a powerful voice, given the word of command, 'Fermel' which regulates manoeuvres of strength. Then he drew himself up.

'Oh! oh!' said he, 'what is this all about? Have I to do with men of straw? Corne de bœuf! stand on one side, and you shall see how this is to be done.'

'Peste!' said D'Arragnan, 'will he pretend to raise that rock? that would be a sight worth looking at.'

The workmen, as commanded by the engineer, drew back with their ears down, and shaking their heads, with the exception of the one who held the plank, who prepared to perform the office. The man with the feathers went up to the stone, stooped, slipped his hands under the face lying upon the ground, stiffened his Herculean muscles, and without a strain, with a slow motion, like that of a machine, lifted the end of the rock a foot from the ground. The workman who held the plank profited by the space thus given him, and slipped the roller under the stone.

'That's the way,' said the giant, not letting the rock fall again, but placing it upon its support.

'Mordieux!' cried D'Arragnan, 'I know but one man capable of such a feat of strength.'

'Hein!' cried the colossus, turning round.

'Porthos!' murmured D'Arragnan, seized with stupor, 'Porthos at Belle-Isle!'

On his part, the man with the feathers fixed his eyes upon the disguised lieutenant, and, in spite of his metamorphosis, recognized him. 'D'Arragnan!' cried he; and the colour mounted to his face. 'Hush!' said he to D'Arragnan.

'Hush!' in his turn, said the musketeer. In fact, if Porthos had just been discovered by D'Arragnan, D'Arragnan had just been discovered by Porthos. The interest of the particular secret of each struck them both at the same instant. Nevertheless the first movement of the two men was to throw their arms around each other. What they wished to conceal from the bystanders, was not their friendship, but their names. But, after the embrace, came reflection.

'To your health!' said Jupenet, quite enchanted.

'To yours, mordieux, to yours. But—an instant—not in this cider. It is an abominable drink, unworthy of a man who quenches his thirst at the Hippocrène fountain—is not it so you call your fountain, you poets?'

'Yes, monsieur, our fountain is so called. That comes from two Greek words—hippos, which means a horse, and—'

'Monsieur,' interrupted D'Arragnan, 'you shall drink of a liquor which comes from one single French word, and is none the worse for that—from the word grape; this cider gives me the heartburn. Allow me to inquire of your host if there is not a good bottle of Beaugency, or of the Ceran growth, at the back of the large bins in his cellar.'

The host, being sent for, immediately attended.

'Monsieur,' interrupted the poet, 'take care, we shall not have time to drink the wine, unless we make great haste, for I must take advantage of the tide to secure the boat.'

'What boat?' asked D'Arragnan.

'Why the boat which sets out for Belle-Isle.'

'Ah—for Belle-Isle?' said the musketeer, 'that is good.'

'Bah! you will have plenty of time, monsieur,' replied the hotelier, uncorking the bottle, 'the boat will not leave this hour.'

'But who will give me notice?' said the poet.

'Your fellow-traveller,' replied the host.

'But I scarcely know him.'

'When you hear him departing, it will be time for you to go.'

'Is he going to Belle-Isle, likewise, then?'

'Yes.'

'The traveller who has a lackey?' asked D'Arragnan. 'He is some gentleman, no doubt?'

'I know nothing of him.'

'What!—know nothing of him?'

'No, all I know is, that he is drinking the same wine as you.'

'Peste!—that is a great honour for us,' said D'Arragnan, filling his companion's glass, whilst the host went out.

'So,' resumed the poet, returning to his dominant ideas, 'you never saw any printing done?'

'Never.'

'Can you guess, now, what this is?' continued the poet.

'No,' said D'Arragnan, 'no, ma foi!'

'Well, monsieur,' said M. Jupenet, 'this little piece of metal is a printing letter.'

'Bah!'

'A capital.'

'Stop, stop, stop,' said D'Arragnan, opening his eyes very innocently.

'Yes, monsieur, a capital; the first letter of my name.'

'And this is a letter, is it?'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'Well, I will confess one thing to you.'

'And what is that?'

'No, I will not, I was going to say something stupid.'

'No, no,' said Master Jupenet, with a patronizing air.

'Well, then, I cannot comprehend, if that is a letter, how you can make a word.'

'A word?'

'Yes, a printed word.'

'Oh, that's very easy.'

'Let me see.'

'Does it interest you?'

'Enormously.'

'Well, I will explain the thing to you. Attend.'

'I am attending.'

'This is it.'

'Good.'

'Look attentively.'

'I am looking.' D'Arragnan, in fact, appeared absorbed in observations.

Jupenet drew from his pocket seven or eight other pieces of brass smaller than the first.

'Ah, ah,' said D'Arragnan.

'What!'

'You have, then, a whole printing-office in your pocket. Peste! that is curious, indeed.'

'Is it not?'

'Good God, what a number of things we learn by traveling.'

'What the devil brings Porthos to Belle-Isle, lifting stones?' said D'Arragnan; only D'Arragnan uttered that question in a low voice. Less strong in diplomacy than his friend, Porthos thought aloud.

'How the devil did you come to Belle-Isle?' asked he of D'Arragnan; 'and what do you want to do here?' It was necessary to reply without hesitation. To hesitate in answer to Porthos would have been a check, for which the self-love of D'Arragnan would never have consoled itself.

'Pardieu! my friend, I am at Belle-Isle because you are here.'

'Ah, bah!' said Porthos, visibly stupefied with the argument and seeking to account for it to himself, with the felicity of deduction we know to be particular to him.

'Without doubt,' continued D'Arragnan, unwilling to give his friend time to recollect himself, 'I have been to see you at Pierrefonds.'

'Indeed!'

'Yes.'

'And you did not find me there?'

'No, but I found Mouston.'

'Is he well?'

'Peste!'

'Well, but Mouston did not tell you I was here.'

'Why should he not? Have I, perchance, deserved to lose his confidence?'

'No; but he did not know it.'

'Well; that is a reason at least that does not offend my self-love.'

'Then how did you manage to find me?'

'My dear friend, a great noble like you always leaves traced behind him on his passage; and I should think but poorly of myself, if I were not sharp enough to follow the traces of my friends.' This explanation, flattering as it was, did not entirely satisfy Porthos.

'But I left no traces behind me, for I came here disguised,' said Porthos.

'Ah! You came disguised did you?' said D'Arragnan.

'Yes.'

'And how?'

'As a miller.'

'And do you think a great noble, like you, Porthos, can affect common manners so as to deceive people?'

‘Well, I swear to you my friend, that I played my part so well that everybody was deceived.’

‘Indeed! so well, that I have not discovered and joined you?’

‘Yes; but how did you discover and join me?’

‘Stop a bit. I was going to tell you how. Do you imagine Mouston—’

‘Ah! it was that fellow, Mouston,’ said Porthos, gathering up those two triumphant arches which served him for eyebrows.

‘But stop, I tell you—it was no fault of Mouston’s because he was ignorant of where you were.’

‘I know he was; and that is why I am in such haste to understand—’

‘Oh! how impatient you are, Porthos.’

‘When I do not comprehend, I am terrible.’

‘Well, you will understand. Aramis wrote to you at Pierrefonds, did he not?’

‘Yes.’

‘And he told you to come before the equinox.’

‘That is true.’

‘Well! that is it,’ said D’Artagnan, hoping that this reason would mystify Porthos. Porthos appeared to give himself up to a violent mental labour.

‘Yes, yes,’ said he, ‘I understand. As Aramis told me to come before the equinox, you have understood that that was to join him. You then inquired where Aramis was, saying to yourself, “Where Aramis is, there Porthos will be.” You have learnt that Aramis was in Bretagne, and you said to yourself, “Porthos is in Bretagne.”’

‘Exactly. In good truth, Porthos, I cannot tell why you have not turned conjuror. So you understand that, arriving at Roche-Bernard, I heard of the splendid fortifications going on at Belle-Isle. The account raised my curiosity, I embarked in a fishing boat, without dreaming that you were here: I came, and I saw a monstrous fine fellow lifting a stone Ajax could not have stirred. I cried out, “Nobody but the Baron de Bracieux could have performed such a feat of strength.” You heard me, you turned round, you recognized me, we embraced; and, *ma foi!* if you like, my dear friend, we will embrace again.’

‘Ah! now all is explained,’ said Porthos; and he embraced D’Artagnan with so much friendship as to deprive the musketeer of his breath for five minutes.

the goodness to repeat to me a part of your tragedy presently, by way of dessert, for instance. That will be sugared roast meat,—*mordoux!* Ah! pardon me, monsieur, that was a little oath which escaped me, because it is a habit with my lord and master. I sometimes allow myself to usurp that little oath, as it seems in pretty good taste. I take this liberty only in his absence, please to observe, for you may understand that in his presence—but, in truth, monsieur, this cider is abominable; do you not think so? And besides, the pot is of such an irregular shape it will not stand on the table.’

‘Suppose we were to make it level?’

‘To be sure; but with what?’

‘With this knife.’

‘And the teal, with what shall we cut that up? Do you not, by chance, mean to touch the teal?’

‘Certainly.’

‘Well, then—’

‘Wait.’

And the poet rummaged in his pocket, and drew out a piece of brass, oblong, quadrangular, about a line in thickness, and an inch and a half in length. But scarcely had this little piece of brass seen the light, than the poet appeared to have committed an imprudence, and made a movement to put it back again in his pocket. D’Artagnan perceived this, for he was a man that nothing escaped. He stretched forth his hand towards the piece of brass: ‘*Humph!* that which you hold in your hand is pretty; will you allow me to look at it?’

‘Certainly,’ said the poet, who appeared to have yielded too soon to a first impulse. ‘Certainly, you may look at it: but it will be in vain for you to look at it,’ added he, with a satisfied air; ‘if I were not to tell you its use, you would never guess it.’

D’Artagnan had seized as an avowal the hesitation of the poet, and his eagerness to conceal the piece of brass which a first movement had induced him to take out of his pocket. His attention, therefore, once awakened on this point, he surrounded himself with a circumspection which gave him a superiority on all occasions. Besides, whatever M. Jupenet might say about it, by a simple inspection of the object, he perfectly well knew what it was. It was a character in printing.